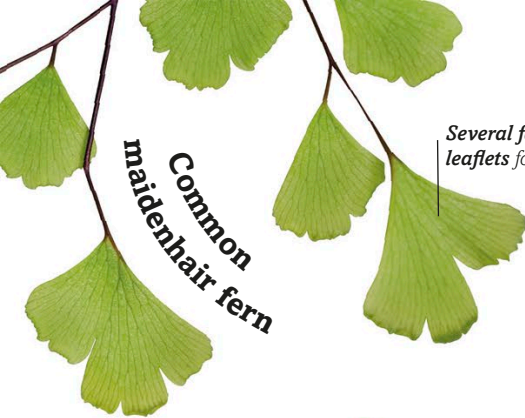




Common
maidenhair fern

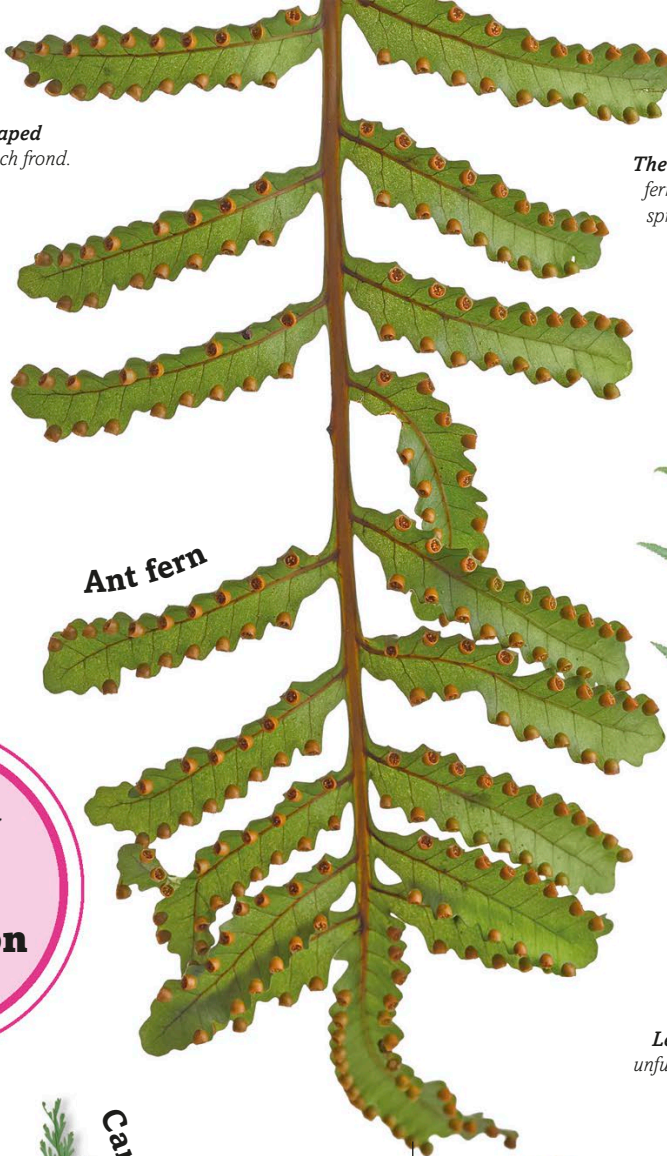
Several fan-shaped
leaflets form each frond.



Heart leaf fern

These glossy leaves
can be heart- or
arrow-shaped.

Fossil
records show
that **ferns**
date back
360 million
years.



Ant fern

Spore-producing
cups line the edges
of each frond.

The leaves of this
fern are silvery in
spring and green
in summer.



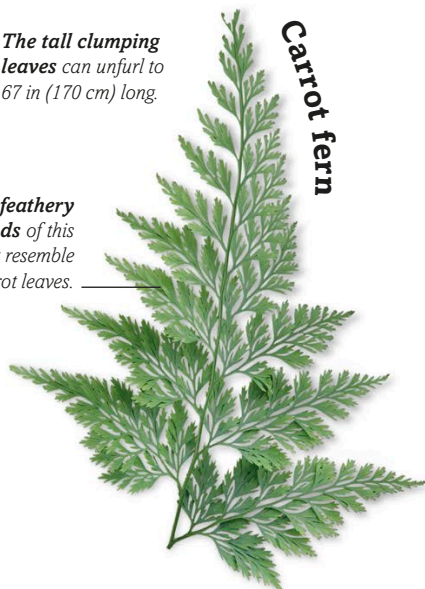
Japanese
painted fern



Ostrich fern

The tall clumping
leaves can unfurl to
67 in (170 cm) long.

The feathery
fronds of this
plant resemble
carrot leaves.



Carrot fern



Leaf segments
unfurl as the main
stalk unrolls.

Bracken



Bracken on forest floor

Tufts of bracken
thrive in open forests
and pastures.

There are about 10,500 known species of ferns some of which have simple undivided fronds, such as those of the **hart's tongue fern** and the **heart leaf fern**. Most are green, but a few have unusual colors, like the purple-veined, silvery leaves of the **Japanese painted fern**. In many

species, the spore-producing brown regions on the underside of fronds are arranged in distinct patterns or shapes, such as the lines of speckles on the **Japanese holly fern**. The tiny spores are usually carried away by the wind, although ants living in the hollow stems of the **ant fern** may also help this plant spread its spores.